> Beware! One more word and I'll answer you with the blade of my sword!' Burnes, to cover his confusion, had the man clapped into irons and thrown into a dungeon like a common murderer.

In Munshi Abdul Karim's version, it is this soldier's relatives who deliver the coup de grâce to Burnes:

> Twelve relatives of the young soldier crowded into Burnes's room. Two grabbed him, forced him down, sat on his chest, shouting: 'You animal! You dare to defile girls of noble birth? If you're supposed to be head of the courts of justice, just tell us, what punishment awaits such scum? What do the law books of the Jews, the Christians, the Zoroastrians have to say?' Burnes pleaded for his life, begging forgiveness – but the Afghans were not to be moved. They killed him, hacked his body to pieces, shaved off his beard and exhibited his head through the streets of the city, after plundering and setting fire to his house, and killing any who came to his aid. The rioters ran to the jail, overpowered the guards and killed them, and set free the young soldier and other prisoners. Another group attacked the Bakshi's treasury, mowing down with their swords all the guards and officials they found there, then plundered the contents of the treasury.[11]

A third version, preferred by the great Victorian chronicler of the Afghan War, Sir John Kaye, has a 'mysterious Kashmiri Mussalman' offer to save Burnes as the flames engulfed his house. This enigmatic figure – who appears in no other account – is alleged to have made his way to the balcony where the two Burnes brothers were defying the crowd and, swearing on the Qur'an, offered to lead them to safety through the back garden. Since it was clear by now that Macnaghten had no intention of saving his young assistant, both the Burnes brothers 'threw on native dresses' and followed their guide down into the garden, hoping that they might yet escape. But they had gone only a few paces before the 'Kashmiri Judas shouted at the top of his voice: "See, friends! This is Sikunder Burnes!" It took the mob less than a minute to finish off the victims.'[12]

Mohan Lal gives a fourth version, probably the most credible, and certainly the most moving. He states that, after spending an hour locked in the zenana closet, he pleaded with Mohammad Zaman Khan, and his host finally consented to allow him up on to his roof. By this time it was all over: Burnes, his travelling companion and intimate friend for ten years, had been killed, and the remains of his house were being gutted by fire. But according to the Nawab's guards, who had watched the final act from their parapet,